

Aspidiske
6,270 Suns

Canopus
13,855 Suns

Eta Carinae
More than 5 million Suns

CARINA

THE KEEL

A PROMINENT SOUTHERN CONSTELLATION, CARINA CONTAINS THE SECOND-BRIGHTEST STAR IN THE SKY, CANOPUS, ALONG WITH RICH MILKY WAY STAR FIELDS.

Carina represents the hull of the mythical ship *Argo*, which the ancient Greeks visualized as a single large constellation. This constellation was split into three (Carina, Vela, the sails, and Puppis, the stern) by the 18th-century French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille, and its two brightest stars, Canopus and Miaplacidus, ended up in Carina.

Carina contains one of the most extraordinary stars known, Eta Carinae. Currently just visible to the naked eye, it flared up in 1843 to become temporarily brighter than Canopus. It is thought to be a massive binary, obscured by the debris thrown off in the great eruption. It lies within the Carina Nebula (see pp.204–205), a cloud of gas that is larger and brighter than the Orion Nebula. The stars Epsilon and Iota Carinae, together with Delta and Kappa Velorum, form the so-called False Cross, an asterism that resembles the true Southern Cross.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 34
Brightest stars Canopus (α) -0.7, Miaplacidus (β) 1.7
Genitive Carinae
Abbreviation Car
Highest in sky at 10pm January–April
Fully visible 14°N–90°S



CHART 2

MAIN STARS

Canopus Alpha (α) Carinae
White giant
-0.7 ↔ 310 light-years

Miaplacidus Beta (β) Carinae
Blue-white giant
1.7 ↔ 113 light-years

Epsilon (ϵ) Carinae
Orange giant
2.0 ↔ 600 light-years

Theta (θ) Carinae
Blue-white main-sequence star
2.8 ↔ 455 light-years

Aspidiske Iota (ι) Carinae
White supergiant
2.3 ↔ 770 light-years

Upsilon (υ) Carinae
White supergiant
3.0 ↔ 1,400 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

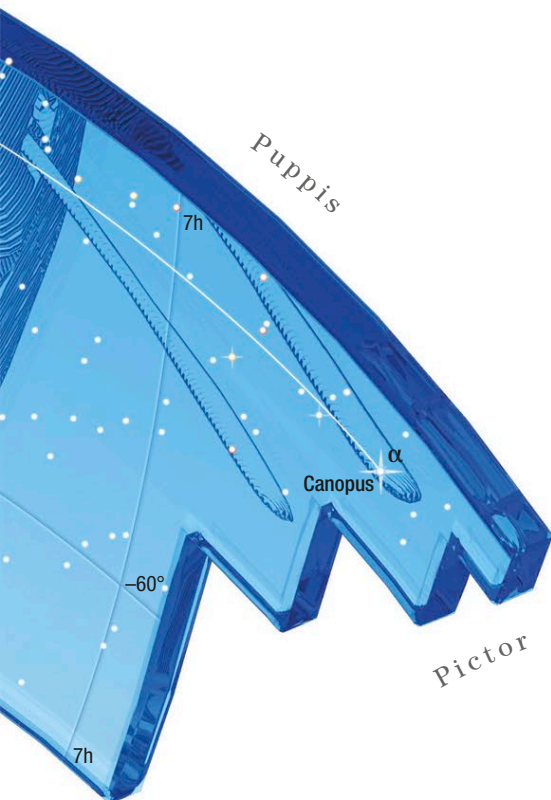
NGC 2516
Open cluster

NGC 3114
Open cluster

NGC 3372 (Carina Nebula)
Bright diffuse nebula

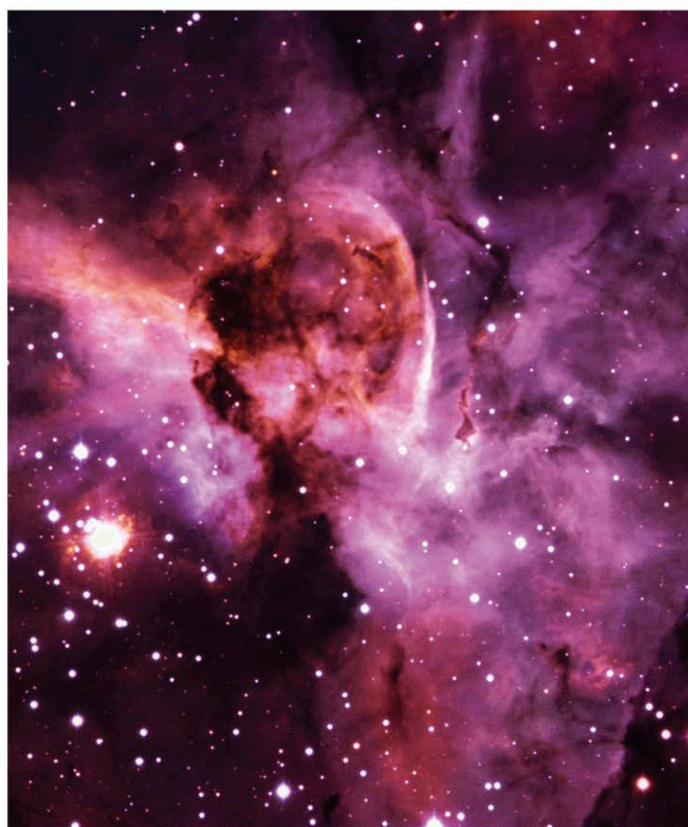
NGC 3532
Open cluster

IC 2602 (Southern Pleiades)
Open cluster



△ NGC 3603

This combined visible light and infrared image reveals an enormous cavity in the gas around the massive star cluster NGC 3603. The cavity was created by ultraviolet radiation and stellar winds from young, hot stars in the cluster.



◁ Eta Carinae and the Keyhole Nebula

A bright area of glowing gas surrounds the binary star Eta Carinae (center left of the image), thrown off in its eruption of 1843. Eta Carinae lies within the Carina Nebula, which includes the region called the Keyhole (the elongated darker area just right of Eta Carinae).